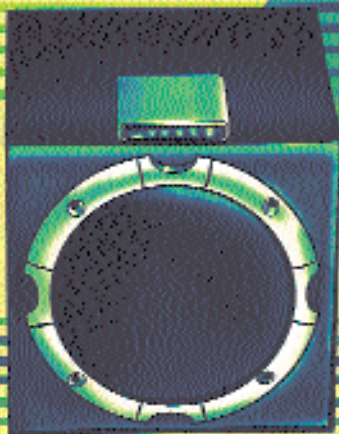




SPEAKERS

Remember when a branded PC came with two speakers with a simple On/Off button and a volume control knob? Today, most branded PCs bundle sub-woofer speaker systems. The reason is mainly because newer motherboards feature onboard sound with up to 7.1 channels. This means we've moved into an era where the PC has become an affordable alternative to a home theatre system—thanks to the advancement in the technology of PC sub-woofers and speakers.

You will find multiple and affordable choices for PC sub-woofer systems in the market, and most often, you're not sure which one would be the right choice for your machine.

Questions To Ask The Dealer

Can I listen to the system?

Ask for a demonstration and test the sample sub-woofer system using music

you're familiar with. To test the bass output, turn the volume high and play a song that produces bass (drum beats and bass guitar); listen carefully to the sound from the sub-woofer and check for cracking or jarring.

If it passes this test, play a song that has stringed instruments such as violins or lead guitar and check the output from the speakers at high and low volumes. If the sound doesn't crack at high volumes then the speakers have passed the test. Finally, if at low volumes the sound is clear and distinct enough for you to be able to distinguish every note variation, you have a real winner.

What sort of warranty do I get?

Don't forget to ask the dealer about replacement warranties because woofers are delicate things to repair. For instance, if the cone of the sub-woofer

is not fixed properly by the engineers, it will result in poor sound output. Thus, a replacement warranty is preferred.

Usage Tips

■ It is appropriate to place the sub-woofer below ear level and on a solid platform. If the woofer fires in horizontal

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direction, with the hole on the woofer being parallel to the ground, place it facing a wall for good bass.

■ If the room is large, angle the speakers towards yourself, and if the room is small, face them towards the walls to get uniform surround sound.

The Future

Computer accessories are getting a lifestyle angle, and so are speakers. Big brands in sound system technology have entered the computer speaker market, challenging the big companies by providing high-quality Dolby Digital systems.

The future will see more advancements in THX technology, and the development of separate, powerful amplifiers that can be interfaced with a PC sound card producing output in excess of 150 watts rms.

Now is perhaps not the right time to invest in a home theatre, especially if you're buying a top-of-the-line PC and speaker system! Also look for wireless speakers with THX certification. ■



Points To Ponder

What are my requirements?

The type of music you listen to is a crucial parameter: it helps you decide on a two-speaker or sub-woofer system. If you are not very particular about the quality of sound output, and the music you listen doesn't produce too much bass, you can settle for a two-speaker system; otherwise, you will need a sub-woofer system.

What else should I know before I buy?

Check if your sound card or on-board sound supports more than two channels. If the sound card is two-channel, then a 5.1 sub-woofer will not produce actual 5.1-channel output. You can override this problem by employing a good sound card with 5.1-channel (or above) sound. This will add to the overall cost of a sub-woofer speaker system. A speaker set's manufacturer specification is all-important. Most manufacturers specify the output as PMPO (Peak Music Power Output),

which is not a true measure of the amplifier, and so you must check the RMS power rating. Any rating above 20 watt RMS is very good. Also, prefer a speaker set with a wired or wireless remote control for the sake of convenience.

Are there any physical considerations?

Yes. Wood is an ideal material for sound systems, and so a sub-woofer with a wooden casing is a good choice. Gold-plated connectors are preferred because gold plating eliminates oxidation of connectors and provides low resistance, thus improving the output quality; the heat dissipation also improves due to gold plating. Gold-plated connectors may not be part of the pack, so you may have to buy them separately. The size of the sub-woofer should be proportional to the RMS power; small size and high output power will result in cracking of sound due to quick and multiple sound reflections.